WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

SLOVENIA

Europe

Information current as of November 2026

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

office@lordwaverley.com
www.lordwaverley.com

WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Ljubljana	Capital and business centre; seat of government, Banka Slovenije and most international firms, with a skilled, multilingual workforce	ICT, business services, finance, pharmaceuticals
Koper and the Divača–Koper rail corridor	Slovenia's Adriatic port, now served by the new 27 km second rail track to Divača, which entered operation in March 2026	Port logistics, distribution, automotive and container trade
Krško (Posavje)	Site of the existing nuclear plant co-owned with Croatia and of the planned JEK2 second unit, the country's largest prospective investment	Nuclear energy, engineering, construction services
Maribor and Styria	Second city and traditional industrial centre close to Austria, which is Slovenia's largest foreign investor	Automotive components, metalworking, logistics
Novo mesto (Dolenjska)	Export-oriented manufacturing region on the motorway towards Zagreb	Pharmaceuticals, automotive, machinery
Celje and Savinja–Šalek region	Central industrial belt with established engineering and energy activity	Home appliances, metals, energy transition projects

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- SPIRIT Slovenia, the public business development agency, supports foreign investors with site selection, information and access to incentives
- Investment grants for qualifying projects, with strategic-investment status for manufacturing and service projects of at least €40 million and 200 new jobs, or R&D projects of at least €20 million and 100 jobs
- Corporate income tax of 22% for 2024–2028 (19% plus a temporary post-flood surcharge), offset by a 100% R&D allowance and a 40% allowance for equipment and intangibles
- Euro-area membership: the euro is the national currency and Banka Slovenije is part of the Eurosystem, with free capital movement under EU rules
- EU single-market and Schengen membership, giving free movement of goods, services, capital and people and passport-free travel to Italy, Austria and Hungary
- EU co-financing through the Recovery and Resilience Plan and cohesion programmes, which keep public investment at about 5.5% of GDP in 2026

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Slovenia in November 2026 offers investors a high-income, AA-rated euro-area economy at the crossroads of Central Europe, the Adriatic and the Western Balkans, and it is currently one of the fastest-growing economies in the euro area. GDP grew 4.8% year-on-year in the second quarter of 2026, the strongest rate since early 2022, and 4.1% in the first half, against 1.0% for the euro area; fixed investment rose 13.2%, construction 15.9% and manufacturing 4.3%. Unemployment was just 3.8% in June 2026. Real growth in 2025 has been revised up to 1.5%. The stock of inward FDI reached €24.0 billion at the end of 2025, up 4.0%, led by Austria, Luxembourg and Switzerland, with manufacturing taking 34.1%. The new government of Prime Minister Janez Janša, confirmed in June 2026, has made the JEK2 nuclear project an absolute priority.

Slovenia's main structural challenge is keeping public finances on a sound footing while funding defence, an ageing population and a large energy investment programme. The deficit rose to 2.5% of GDP in 2025 and the revised 2026 budget, adopted on 1 October 2026, targets 2.9%, including extra spending that lifts defence to 2.03% of GDP; the 2027 and 2028 budgets aim to keep the deficit below 3%. Inflation was 3.3% in October 2026. The starting position is strong: public debt fell to 65.1% of GDP in 2025 and is estimated at 64.6% in 2026, and S&P (AA) and Fitch (A+) affirmed their ratings with stable outlooks in September 2026. As Recovery Plan funding ends in 2027, EU cohesion funds and national financing are expected to keep public investment high, creating continued opportunities in energy, transport and digital infrastructure.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Corporate tax surcharge	The temporary post-flood surcharge raises corporate tax to 22% until 2028, above many regional competitors	Use the 100% R&D and 40% investment allowances; the rate is due to revert to 19% from 2029 unless new legislation intervenes
Fiscal pressures and policy changes	The deficit is targeted at 2.9% of GDP in 2026 and 2027, and a referendum on 6 December 2026 will decide a law cutting VAT on staple foods and capping social contributions	Debt is falling and ratings are stable; build scenarios for both referendum outcomes into labour-cost and pricing plans
Labour availability	With unemployment at 3.8%, skilled workers are scarce and wage pressure is rising	Plan early recruitment, use local employment-office training support and automate where possible
Inflation and energy costs	Inflation was 3.3% in October 2026, with housing and utilities up 8.6%	Euro-area membership brings ECB monetary policy; build energy-price scenarios into business plans and consider long-term supply contracts
Political change	The March 2026 election brought a change of government; the five-party coalition holds 43 of 90 seats and relies on outside support for key votes	Policy direction on nuclear energy and growth is clear; maintain dialogue with ministries and track legislation closely
Large-project timelines	JEK2 is estimated at €9.6–15.4 billion, and a final investment decision is expected only later in the decade	Position early through supplier registration and partnerships with GEN energija; the government intends to accelerate the project

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Slovenia's risk profile is that of a stable, high-income EU and euro-area member with strong credit ratings, low unemployment and falling public debt. The economy has accelerated in 2026 on the back of investment and construction, and the country is not subject to sanctions or FATF listing. The main near-term considerations are domestic: a temporary 22% corporate tax rate to 2028, a deficit close to the EU's 3% reference value, rising labour costs and the outcome of the 6 December 2026 referendum on tax and contribution changes. These are manageable within a clear EU fiscal framework and are offset by generous R&D and investment allowances. Investors benefit from the legal certainty of EU law, the convenience of the euro and Schengen access to neighbouring Italy, Austria, Hungary and Croatia.

MARKET ACCESS

As a member of the EU, Slovenia gives investors tariff-free access to the EU single market and to all the EU's free trade agreements, with WTO membership and the EU's common trade policy governing trade with third countries. The euro removes exchange-rate costs for trade with euro-area partners, and Schengen membership allows border-free movement to its EU neighbours. The Port of Koper is a gateway for Central European trade with Asia and the Mediterranean, and the new Divača–Koper second track, operational since March 2026, adds rail capacity on the route to Austria, Hungary and beyond. Slovenia's position and language links also make it a natural base for serving the Western Balkans, and Austria, Switzerland and Germany are among its leading investors.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Government of Slovenia (Prime Minister Janez Janša)	Five-party coalition confirmed on 4 June 2026; sets fiscal, energy and reform policy	Primary reference point for strategic direction and major projects
SPIRIT Slovenia	Public business development agency supporting foreign investors, grants and internationalisation	Standard first point of contact for market entry and incentives
Banka Slovenije	National central bank within the Eurosystem; its governor sits on the ECB Governing Council, which held the deposit rate at 2.50% on 29 October 2026	Relevant for banking, payments and financial-sector matters
Ministry of Finance	Leads the budget, tax policy, debt management and EU fiscal compliance	Key counterpart on tax, fiscal and public-finance matters
Ministry of Infrastructure and Energy (Minister Jernej Vrtovec)	Oversees transport, energy and the JEK2 project, which the minister calls an absolute priority	Relevant for energy, rail and port investment
GEN energija	State energy group, co-owner of the Krško plant and investor in JEK2, refining the project's financing model	Essential partner for nuclear and power-sector engagement
Ministry responsible for the economy	Oversees industrial policy, SPIRIT Slovenia and investment incentives	Relevant for grants, strategic-investment status and manufacturing

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Chamber of Commerce and Industry of Slovenia, the American Chamber of Commerce Slovenia, the British-Slovenian Chamber of Commerce and the Slovenian-German Chamber of Commerce are the main business associations, with regular dialogue with government. SPIRIT Slovenia and its regional network help investors find partners and incentives, while municipalities negotiate local support such as sites and utility connections case by case. The European Investment Bank and the EU's cohesion and recovery programmes co-finance infrastructure and innovation projects, and GEN energija's JEK2 programme offers a channel for engineering and supply-chain firms. Embassies of major EU partners and the United States maintain commercial sections that are a useful source of introductions.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Slovenia suits investors seeking a high-skill, well-governed base inside the EU and the euro area: manufacturers in automotive, pharmaceuticals and machinery serving Central European supply chains; logistics companies using the Port of Koper and the new Divača–Koper rail link; R&D-intensive and ICT firms able to use the 100% R&D allowance; energy and engineering investors targeting the JEK2 nuclear project, grid and renewables; and companies using Slovenia as a regional headquarters for the Western Balkans.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage SPIRIT Slovenia and assess incentives
Open dialogue with the agency to test eligibility for investment grants, strategic-investment status and tax allowances.

STEP 2: Model the tax position to 2029
Plan for the 22% rate to 2028 and its scheduled return to 19%, using R&D and investment allowances to reduce the tax base.

STEP 3: Shortlist sites with municipalities
Compare locations near Ljubljana, Maribor, Novo mesto and Koper, and negotiate local support on land and utility connections.

STEP 4: Track the December 2026 referendum and 2027 budget
Monitor changes to VAT, social contributions and spending, and build both outcomes into labour-cost and pricing models.

STEP 5: Position for JEK2 and energy projects
Build relationships with GEN energija and the energy ministry ahead of vendor selection and the final investment decision.